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Hospital fire kills 3 infants in Telangana

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Elections to 12 Rajya Sabha seats on Oct. 16

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FREEZING DEMOCRACY

An attack on the electorate

Election Commission is functioning as a tool of the BJP in West Bengal

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GOLDEN DAY

Harmanpreet & Co. on top of the podium

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IN BRIEF



SIR notices seem 'mechanically issued' in Delhi: SC

NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said the notices sent by the EC during the SIR in Delhi to 33 lakh voters seem to be "machine-generated" without any application of mind. » Page 13

IIT-B student's parents demand arrest of professor

MUMBAI

Days after a student of IIT Bombay was found dead in his hostel room, his parents have demanded the arrest of a faculty member and the institute's director. » Page 14

OPPORTUNITIES » PAGE 5

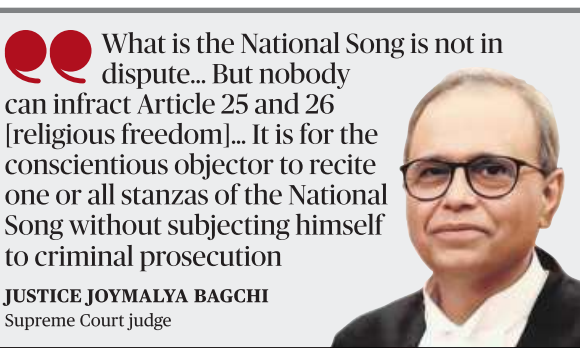
Cannot penalise refusal to sing National Song, says SC

Top court seeks response from the Union government on a plea by renowned Carnatic vocalist T.M. Krishna challenging the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act, 2026

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday observed that while a democratically elected government may give shape to the scope and length of the National Song, it cannot violate individual and collective religious freedoms or subject conscientious objectors, who refuse to sing one or all the stanzas of the *Vande Mataram*, to penal consequences.

"What is the National Song is not in dispute... It is for the democratically-elected state to decide and give aspiration as to what the National Song is, whether it should be two stanzas or four stanzas. But nobody can infract Article 25 and 26 [religious freedom] or subject a conscientious objector to pe-



What is the National Song is not in dispute... But nobody can infract Article 25 and 26 [religious freedom]... It is for the conscientious objector to recite one or all stanzas of the National Song without subjecting himself to criminal prosecution

JUSTICE JOYMALYA BAGCHI
Supreme Court judge

nal consequences... It is for the conscientious objector to recite one or all stanzas of the National Song without subjecting himself to criminal prosecution," Justice Joyimalya Bagchi, part of a three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, observed. He said the 1986 Supreme Court precedent in *Bijoe Emmanuel versus State of Kerala*, upholding the right to religious free-

dom, constitutional tolerance, and silent objection, still holds true.

The court sought a response from the Union government on a petition filed by renowned Carnatic vocalist and author T.M. Krishna challenging the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Act, 2026, read with the administrative directions issued by the Union Home Ministry in January

and a subsequent circular in July.

Mr. Krishna, represented by senior advocate S. Muralidhar and advocate Prasanna S., said the amended law and executive orders compel the playing and mass singing of the entire six stanzas of *Vande Mataram* ahead of the National Anthem at public functions. Non-compliance would risk three years' imprisonment or fine or both.

Stanzas three to six of *Vande Mataram* were "expressly devotional, deity-invoking, and non-secular", and the scheme violated fundamental rights guaranteed under the Constitution and offended the basic feature of secularism, the petitioner said.

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» PAGE 12

17-year-old girl gang-raped at public park in Delhi by 3 men posing as police personnel

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

A 17-year-old girl was gang-raped by three men who posed as police personnel at Astha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Mandir in south-east Delhi on Monday night. The girl's 17-year-old male friend was also assaulted, police said.

The accused were identified as Asif, 31, an onion wholesaler at Srinivaspuri market and resident of Tughlakabad; Hemanth, 31, who claims to be an advocate practising at the Saket Courts and is preparing for competitive exams; and his brother Mukesh, 24, a BSc student from Palwal in Haryana. The brothers are residents of Srinivaspuri. All three accused were arrested on Tuesday. Asif was shot in the leg during a police operation on Tuesday morning.

The girl made a distress



Special staff of the Delhi police conducting an investigation at the encounter site after one of the accused was held on Tuesday. ANI

call at 8.45 p.m., after which Amar Colony police personnel reached Astha Kunj Park. She was found at the spot with her male friend, the police said. The girl was subsequently medically examined at AIIMS while the Crime Team and Forensic Science Laboratory personnel examined the scene and collected evi-

dence, the police said.

A case was registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

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Making a mark



Conservationist Purnima Devi Barman, right, who was named the *businessline* Changemaker of the Year, with Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and the Director and Publisher of The Hindu Group, Nirmala Lakshman, in New Delhi on Tuesday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR (REPORT: PAGE 13)

Main accused held in sexual harassment case in Bihar

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

The prime accused in a case of molestation of a Class 10 girl and her male friend was arrested following a police encounter on Tuesday in Bihar's Jamui.

Nandan Yadav sustained injuries in his leg during the encounter while co-accused Hare Ram Yadav injured his leg while trying to escape, the police said.

DETAILS ON
» PAGE 12

Trade agreement unlikely till U.S. probes India's competitor countries

Sriram Lakshman
WASHINGTON DC

India and the U.S. are unlikely to sign a trade deal until the U.S. launches a series of fresh 'Section 301 investigations', concludes them, and places tariffs on India's competitors such as Pakistan, Sri Lanka, and the Philippines, a person familiar with the process has said. It was a "strategic mistake" that Pakistan was not included in the list of countries investigated in the 'excess capacity' 301 investigations opened in March 2026, according to the person.

An announcement of fresh 301 investigations against some of India's competitor countries is likely in the near future, *The Hindu* has learned, although the timelines and the subject matters for these 301s have not yet

Uneven markets

The U.S. uses 'Section 301' as an alternative to the 'reciprocal tariffs'

India, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka were subject to probes for 'forced labour', but only India is on the probe list for 'excess capacity'

India is likely to face 8% tariff in the 'excess capacity' investigation to bring the overall tariff rate it faces up to 18%

been decided.

For this reason, it is highly unlikely that a trade deal will be concluded around Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal's upcoming visit to the North American country for the G-20 trade ministerial that starts on September 30.

These developments appear to be consistent with Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal's remarks at the Global Fintech Fest 2026 earlier this month. Mr. Agrawal had said that India operates largely on an MFN (Most Favoured Nation) tariff basis, while the U.S. operates on an executive tariff basis, and that a trade agreement would require an architecture with differentials and preferential market access structure for India.

Supreme Court ruling

The '301s' are part of how the U.S. government is working around the February 2026 U.S. Supreme Court ruling that President Donald Trump's 'reciprocal' tariffs were an unlawful application of the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA). Prior to this ruling, In-

dia and the U.S. had arrived at an Interim Agreement on trade that was announced via an India-U.S. joint statement issued on February 6.

The general tariff rate for Indian goods entering the U.S. under the interim deal was going to be 18%, giving India an advantage over its main competitors. These include not just Pakistan (19%), which is the most politically sensitive country in New Delhi's calculus, but also Vietnam (20%), Sri Lanka (20%), Bangladesh (19%) and the Philippines (19%). Nepal and the Maldives did not fall under the reciprocal tariff schedule and were tariffed at 10%. Following the scrapping of these tariffs, they trade with the U.S. on an MFN basis.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 12

Lady Shri Ram College for Women (LSR) suspended regular classes at noon on Tuesday and announced online classes for Wednesday following the police encounter with one of the accused men in the Kalkaji gang rape case. The shootout happened barely 50 metres from the college's back gate. The college administration said student safety is its top priority.

The incident raised safety concerns among the students. "I was not able to travel alone from college to my PG in Greater Kailash," said a student, requesting anonymity. She said they were now travelling in groups.

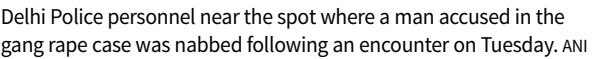
The LSR Students' Union conducted an online meeting to discuss students' concerns and safety demands, including stronger security around the college perimeter.

Safety concerns at Astha Kunj Park not new: residents; DDA reviewing security

Residents near Astha Kunj Park, a green space used by joggers and commuters as a shortcut between south-east Delhi neighbourhoods, expressed shock and disbelief after the alleged gang rape of a 17-year-old, even as they voiced long-standing safety concerns in the area – particularly after dark – citing poor lighting.

The park connects three prominent religious sites — ISKCON Temple, Lotus Temple and Kalkaji Mandir. The assault took place nearly 500 metres from the Kalkaji Mandir on Monday. Delhi Metro commuters use the park to reach neighbourhoods such as Sant Nagar, Bhagat Colony and Jagatpur.

Many residents told *The Hindu* that large stretches of its perimeter remain open and in disrepair. A guard room near the entrance by the Nehru Place metro station lies aban-



done and has effectively become a dumping spot for waste, said residents.

On Tuesday, the police cordoned off the 142.10-acre space, which is managed by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA).

In a release, the DDA stated on Tuesday that nine security guards are deployed in the park, along with supervisory and patrolling personnel.

The urban body denied claims of poor lighting and added that it had strengthened security arrangements and was assessing manpower and deployment requirements in view

of the park's size and 29 access points.

‘Sense of dread’

"I have to constantly turn around and see if anyone is following me. That's the feeling," said Gautam*, a Greater Kailash-I resident who regularly jogs there.

This is despite the park being located in the heart of south Delhi, with Kailash Colony market, N Block market and residential areas all being within a kilometre, he added. "Robberies by knife-wielding individuals are not uncommon at stretches with patchy lighting," he said.

Another resident, Atush Kumar, vividly remembers being robbed inside the park more than a decade ago. "I was confronted by a group of men carrying knives who robbed me of all my belongings, including a phone I had bought days ago. My college identity card was the only item they didn't take," he said.

Robbery in June

On June 26, two men robbed a U.S. national at the park at knifepoint.

Monday's incident has changed the way residents view the space, which had been part of their everyday routine for many years.

Reena*, whose children visit the park to play in the evenings, said she would no longer feel comfortable sending them there.

"I used to encourage my daughters to go out and play, but now I don't think I will be okay with them going there, at least for some time," she said.

(*Name changed on request)

L-G visits police HQ, directs setting up of women-centric patrol unit for deterrence

Lieutenant-Governor (L-G) Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Tuesday directed the Delhi police to set up a dedicated "Pink Force" of trained women personnel to patrol around schools, colleges, metro stations and other sensitive areas, particularly during vulnerable hours, for visible deterrence and rapid response, a day after the alleged gang-rape in Kalkaji.



in Delhi. He said women's safety was "non-negotiable" and directed the police to continue focused action against sexual harassment in public spaces under Operation Shishu. The L-G also called for increased foot and bicycle patrolling in crime-prone and high-footfall areas, with particular attention to schools, colleges, markets and transport hubs.

Public outreach

He directed the police in each district to nominate a nodal officer and prepare a quarterly calendar for interactive awareness pro-

grammes in schools on the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, child safety, cybercrime, substance abuse and road safety.

He also called for sustained, intelligence-led action against drug trafficking under the *Nasha Mukti Bharat Abhiyaan* and for strengthening police stations to handle cybercrime complaints and preserve digital evidence.

Tracking complaints

On public grievances, Mr. Sandhu directed the police to introduce a digital tracking mechanism for Jan Sun-wai complaints, with every grievance acknowledged and acted upon within a defined timeline. Complaints concerning other departments should be forwarded to the agency concerned, he said.

The L-G said police stations should be places where citizens feel heard.

The Hindu volume on delimitation debate to be launched in Delhi today



The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A compilation of essays examining critical questions of representation, federalism and demographic change – ‘The Delimitation Debate: The Union and its Units’ – published by The Hindu Group, will be launched in New Delhi on Wednesday.

The question of how many people an elected representative should speak for has never had a settled answer. It has instead been shaped by a political history of shifting compromises.

The strength of the Lok Sabha has been increased three times in the past, but since 1976 the number of MPs has remained unchanged.

The size of Parliament and the constituencies are not merely

matters of demographic arithmetic but political choices. This makes delimitation not just an exercise in drawing boundaries or counting people. It is about deciding how India chooses to be represented.

In addition to these anxieties, there are also concerns about political representation across the North-South divide.

Edited by *The Hindu* Editor Suresh Nambath and curated by Resident Editor (Delhi) Varghese K. George, the book addresses many of these concerns while also clarifying several misconceptions surrounding the delimitation process.

The book launch will be followed by two panel discussions.

The event will start at 6.30 p.m. on Wednesday at the India International Centre, New Delhi.

Oppn. takes on Delhi govt. over gang rape of minor

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Opposition Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and the Congress on Tuesday hit out at the Delhi government over the alleged gang rape of a 17-year-old girl in Astha Kunj Park near Kalkaji Mandir on Monday evening.

While AAP claimed that Delhi Police was busy behaving like a “political tool” instead of acting against criminals, the Congress said Monday’s incident was the fourth reported rape of a minor in the city in 10 days, and it represented the “failure” of the Rekha Gupta government in protecting women.

Unlike other full-fledged

States, in Delhi the police report to the Union Home Ministry.

Addressing mediapersons, AAP Delhi president Saurabh Bharadwaj said, “Delhi Police registers two new cases against me every month. They have so much time. But if a girl approaches the police about harassment, the police won’t register her case.”

Delhi Congress chief Devender Yadav criticised the CM over her “silence” on such crimes.

“Rekha Gupta’s silence on the brutal sexual assaults on minor girls raises questions on the law and order situation in the Capital despite BJP’s ‘triple-engine’ government,” said Mr. Yadav.

INBRIEF



Maharashtra forms Cabinet panel to tackle drought

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Tuesday announced the formation of a Cabinet subcommittee headed by Revenue Minister Chandrashekhhar Bawankule to identify drought-hit areas and take measures to provide relief to farmers. Speaking after a Cabinet meeting, Mr. Fadnavis said officials have been directed to conduct assessment of crop losses in drought-hit areas from Wednesday. He said a preliminary notification regarding the drought situation will be issued by Saturday.

BJP wins six deputy mayoral posts in Rajasthan urban polls

After its victory in the mayoral contests and polling for chairpersons of municipal councils and municipalities in Rajasthan on Monday, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) continued its winning spree for the posts of deputy heads of urban bodies on Tuesday. The ruling party maintained its dominance in the urban local bodies by winning the seats of deputy mayors in six of the seven municipal corporations where the polling was held. A Congress-supported Independent councillor was elected in Pali. Besides seven municipal corporations, the polling was held in 47 municipal councils and 251 municipalities.

Allow Cong. candidate to contest bypoll properly if he gets bail: HC to W.B. govt

Pradhan's lawyer says arrest on Sept. 18 came after he received support from Mamata Banerjee; matter listed for further consideration on October 12; ISF leader files plea over 'almirah' symbol

Press Trust of India
KOLKATA

The Calcutta High Court on Tuesday told the West Bengal government that Congress's Nandigram bypoll candidate Milan Pradhan be allowed to contest the election properly, provided he gets bail in the five criminal cases in which he has been arrested.

Mr. Pradhan was on Saturday sent to judicial custody by the Haldia Sub-Divisional Court until October 3 in connection with four pending non-bailable arrest warrants linked to cases in Nandigram dating back to 2007. On Monday, the Contai court sent the Congress candidate to 14 days' judicial custody, until October 5, in a case under the Arms Act registered nearly two decades ago. The bypoll in Nandigram is slated for October 6. The campaign ends on October 4, and the counting of votes is scheduled for October 9.



Congress leaders staging a protest rally against the arrest of party candidate Milan Pradhan in Kolkata on September 19. PTI

Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya verbally told Additional Advocate General Rajdeep Majumdar, representing the State, that Mr. Pradhan be allowed to contest the election properly, provided he gets bail.

Mr. Pradhan's counsel, Ayan Bhattacharjee, informed the court that he was arrested on September 18 in connection with cases lodged during the anti-land acquisition movement in Nandigram in 2007 only after he received support from the Mamata Banerjee-led All India Trinamool Congress for the bypoll.

Mr. Majumdar informed Justice Bhattacharyya that 11 criminal cases had been registered against Mr. Pradhan, but he was not wanted in the six cases mentioned by his lawyer, in which he had sought protection from coercive police action. Mr. Majumdar also said five of these six cases had been withdrawn by the previous government and in another case registered at Nandigram police station, Mr. Pradhan was not an accused.

The court directed that the matter be listed before him for further consideration on October 12.

Meanwhile, Indian Secular Front leader and MLA Nawsad Siddique on Tuesday moved a petition before the High Court challenging the Election Commission of India's decision to replace the 'envelope' symbol, with which the party fought the April Assembly election, with the 'almirah' symbol. The ISF has put up a candidate for the Nandigram bypoll. The petition is likely to be heard later this week.

Extension sought

The 20 Lok Sabha MPs who quit the Trinamool Congress and aligned themselves with the NCPI have sought another four weeks to respond to notices issued by Speaker Om Birla on petitions seeking their disqualification under the anti-defection law. The deadline granted to them expired on Tuesday. NCPI parliamentary chairperson Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar said the MPs were yet to collate documents required for the response.

Nagaon LS bypoll: BJP, Cong. workers clash for second straight day

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Congress workers clashed for the second successive day during campaigning for the October 6 by-election to the Nagaon parliamentary constituency in Assam.

According to reports, ruling party workers blocked the vehicle of Congress MLA Asif Nazar at Garoimari in Morigaon district on Tuesday and a scuffle between workers of the two parties ensued.

District officials said the situation was brought under control after the police escorted Mr. Nazar's vehicle away from the spot.

On Monday, BJP workers had allegedly attacked the vehicles of Congress leaders who were travelling to Samaguri in adjoining Nagaon district for an election meeting. Among the leaders were State Congress president Gaurav Gogoi and former Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel.

In a complaint to the local police, the Congress claimed that BJP supporters pelted stones at and damaged the vehicle in which its candidate, Siba-



On Monday, BJP workers had allegedly attacked the vehicles of Congress leaders who were travelling to Samaguri. PTI

moni Bora, was travelling.

Internal rivalry: CM Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, however, said the Samaguri clash was between rival factions within the Congress. He advised the Congress leadership to keep its house in order and not let internal differences spill onto the streets.

The Nagaon Lok Sabha seat fell vacant after Pradyut Bordoloi quit the Congress and joined the BJP. He contested and won the Dispur Assembly seat on a BJP ticket in April 2026.

Although 15 candidates are vying for the Nagaon seat, the contest is expected to be among Ms. Bora, the BJP's Devasish Baruah, a former bureaucrat, and All India United Democratic Front chief Mohammed Badruddin Ajmal.

Three infants killed in fire at hospital in Telangana; 25 babies rescued from blaze

Siddharth Kumar Singh
HYDERABAD

Three infants died after a fire broke out at the Special Newborn Care Unit (SNCU) ward of Rajiv Gandhi Institute of Medical Sciences in Adilabad district of Telangana late on Monday.

As many as 25 other infants being treated in the ward were safely rescued.

The rescued infants were shifted to nearby private hospitals for further treatment. A note from the Health Minister C. Damodar Raja Narasimha's office said that they were stable and have not developed any complications.

The two infants who died, aged five and four days respectively, were preterm babies. The third infant, a two-day-old girl was in a critical condition and died while being shifted to a nearby hospital, said Director of Medical



Tragic incident: State Health Minister C. Damodar Raja Narasimha visiting the site of the accident on Tuesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Education (DME) N. Vani. According to Adilabad District Medical and Health Officer (DMHO) Sadhana, the fire was likely caused after an air-conditioner in the reception area of the newborn care unit burst into flames.

A fire tender was rushed to the hospital and the blaze was brought under control. Mr. Narasimha, who visited the site, said that a preliminary inquiry

indicated that an electrical short circuit in an AC unit may have triggered the fire. The police have launched an investigation into the incident. A detailed inquiry by an expert committee would ascertain the exact cause and identify any lapses in safety standards, he added.

Adilabad Superintendent of Police (SP) Akhil Mahajan said the incident occurred around 11.40

p.m., and police teams reached the hospital within three minutes. "Although Ganesh immersion processions were under way and a large number of police personnel were deployed, our teams were able to reach the spot within three minutes and assist in evacuating the children," he said.

Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy expressed grief over the incident and conveyed his condolences to the families of the infants. Mr. Reddy directed officials to ensure better medical treatment for the children undergoing treatment at the hospital and to continuously monitor their health condition.

He ordered an inquiry into the incident. He further instructed authorities to strengthen fire and other safety measures in hospitals across the State to prevent similar incidents.

Maharashtra Congress calls SIR deletions 'alarming', seeks two-month extension

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

A delegation of Maharashtra Congress met the State's Chief Electoral Officer S. Chockalingam on Tuesday and expressed apprehension that 30% of the electorate is likely to be disenfranchised. The leaders raised concerns and anomalies about the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and sought a two-month extension for submitting claims and objections.

In a six-page memorandum submitted to Mr. Chockalingam, the party highlighted widespread discrepancies in voter data, including numerous 'unmapped' and 'anomalous' entries, and the alleged unjustified removal of over two crore voters. The delegation expressed concern about the lack of transparency and adherence to due process, cit-



The Congress said of the 9,78,54,049 names on the electoral rolls before the SIR, 2,06,88,487, i.e. 21.14%, had been dropped. ANI

ing insufficient notice periods for voters and the challenging process for citizens to verify their electoral status.

'Serious questions'

Of the 9,78,54,049 names on the electoral rolls before the SIR, 2,06,88,487, i.e. 21.14%, had been dropped, the party said. Moreover, notices are going to be issued to 1,22,24,007 voters as 'unmapped' or 'anomalous', since their records have

not matched with the 2002 electoral rolls. The Congress termed the deletion of more than 2.06 crore names between the 2024 Assembly election and August 31, 2026, as "unprecedented and alarming".

"... the final voter list is likely to have a reduction of 20 to 25 per cent, which is substantial. It raises serious questions about the SIR process," the six-page memorandum stated.

The party also claimed that 40 lakh new names

Confident of a hat-trick in U.P. Assembly poll: Nabin

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) would retain power in Uttar Pradesh for a third consecutive term in the 2027 Assembly election, party national president Nitin Nabin said on Tuesday.

"Neither our workers nor our leaders are part-time politicians. Our only aim is to serve the public," he said addressing a gathering of office-bearers and workers in Saharanpur, concluding his two-day visit to western U.P., his first after becoming the national president.

"Today I had the opportunity to meet the workers and interact with our senior leaders in Saharanpur and the whole of western Uttar Pradesh. The enthusiasm of the workers and their energy clearly indicate that in 2027, the BJP will again form a government with a thumping ma-



BJP national president Nitin Nabin receiving a warm welcome from party workers in Khatauli, Muzaffarnagar, on Tuesday. @BJP4INDIA X

jority," he said.

Draws road map

Earlier in the day, he held meetings in Saharanpur with several MPs, MLAs and key office-bearers of the party and outlined the road map ahead. During

the interactions, the party chief emphasised strengthening booth-level preparations.

On Monday, he addressed a *Yuva Samvad* programme in Meerut as part of an outreach to the youth.

"Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chief Minister Yogi Adityanathji, there is a public belief in development with cultural heritage. The common man is confident that under these two leaders, the goals of a developed *Viksit Bharat* (Developed India) and *Utam Pradesh* (best State) will be achieved," he said at Tuesday's event, praising the Union and State governments for introducing various welfare measures and ending "lawlessness" in the State.

The BJP chief urged party workers, whom he described as the party's "backbone", to ensure that "lotus blooms again" in U.P.

Differing voices

Meanwhile, west U.P. MPs — Iqra Hasan (Kairana) of the Samajwadi Party (SP) and Imran Masood (Saharanpur) of the Congress — made contradictory claims

over their parties' roles and capabilities in taking on the ruling party ahead of formal discussions on a pre-poll alliance.

Mr. Masood said, "Only [Congress leader and Rae Bareilly MP] Rahul Gandhi is the Opposition's voice across the country, which unnerves the BJP. No one should be under any illusion — nothing is possible without Rahulji."

The Saharanpur MP has been pushing for the two parties to reach an early seat-sharing arrangement while claiming an "equal partner" status for the Congress.

On the other hand, Ms. Hasan said only the SP chief Akhilesh Yadav is capable of defeating the BJP. She added that without her party, the Congress has little hope in U.P.

"Only Akhilesh Yadav is capable of defeating the BJP. On its own, the Congress won't be able to achieve much," she said.

BJP legislator strikes a different note on UCC in Mizoram

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

One of the Bharatiya Janata Party's (BJP) two MLAs in Mizoram has called for a closer examination of the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), in contrast to the State government's opposition to its implementation.

The 40-member Mizoram Assembly adopted a resolution in February 2023 opposing any move to implement the UCC in the State. Chief Minister Lalduhoma recently said the UCC was a threat to indigenous customary laws and minority rights.

BJP legislator K. Hrahmo, however, argued that implementing the UCC could provide greater legal protection to Mizo women married to non-tribal men. He represents the Palak As-

sembly constituency in Siahla district.

Speaking at a party programme at the BJP's office in Aizawl on Monday, Mr. Hrahmo said the implementation of the UCC in Mizoram should be seen in the context of marriages between Mizos and non-Mizos. Mr. Hrahmo said that opposition to laws introduced by the Centre often arises from political considerations or a lack of understanding of their provisions. He said tribal populations have been excluded from the ambit of the UCC and that such exemptions exist in States where it has been implemented.

"The Congress portrayed the UCC as dangerous for political gains, creating apprehension without analysing its provisions," he said.

Odisha: two detained for 'harassing' tourist couple

Press Trust of India
BHUBANESWAR

The Odisha police on Tuesday detained two persons for allegedly harassing a young tourist couple on their way to the hill shrine of Kapilash in Dhenkanal district, an official said.

The police registered a case and detained the two accused after taking cognisance of a video widely shared on social media.

The official said the incident took place on an isolated stretch of a road leading to the Kapilash hills.

The video showed some people intercepting the bike-borne couple and assaulting the man, while the woman shouted for help. "An FIR has been registered at Gondia police station. An investigation is under way," Dhenkanal SP Abhinav Sonkar said.

Keralam govt. orders inquiry into charges against former CM

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Keralam government on Tuesday ordered a police inquiry into the politically charged CMRL-Exalogic payoff controversy centring on Leader of the Opposition and former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Vee-na, and son-in-law and former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas.

Probe Cabinet Ministers named in ledger: CPI(M)

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The CPI(M) on Tuesday dared the Keralam government to investigate Cabinet Ministers allegedly named by acronyms in the “slush fund ledger” supposedly maintained by the Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd. (CMRL). CPI(M) State secretary M.V. Govindan accused the UDF government of being the BJP’s B-team in Keralam.

vocate-General," he said.

However, Mr. Chennithala said the Supreme Court ruled in *Lalita Kumari versus the State of Uttar Pradesh* in 2013 that registering an FIR in a suspected commercial fraud or corruption case depends on whether the mandatory preliminary inquiry reveals a cognisable offence, tempering the demand for immediate registration of a case on the receipt of allegedly inculpatory third-party information.

“The government has tasked the State Police Chief (SPC) with deciding

the nature of the preliminary probe and the investigating agency," he added.

ED's charges

The ED had charged that the CMRL, a chemical company in which the Kerala government has a minority stake, had camouflaged backhanders to Mr Vijayan, when he was Chief Minister, as retainers to Ms Veena's now-defunct software firm Exalogic Solutions during 2017-2021 for consultancy services allegedly not provided.

Last month, the ED had sent a 25-page report to State Police Chief r seeking Mr. Vijayan's prosecution.

The ED had also claimed in the report that it had confiscated a diary detailing the allegedly illicit financial transaction during a raid at Mr. Vijayan's house here in May.

Mr Vijayan had disputed the existence of any incriminating entries in the diary. At the same time, Mr Riyas maintained that the personal journal contained scribbles about Ms Veen's business plans in the Gulf, which, he claimed, had yet to materialise.

‘Legal advice’

In the *Vijay Madanlal Choudhary* versus the Union of India case, the Supreme Court ruled that law enforcement could not buttress its act on the information not shared on record by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) under Section 66 (2) of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act. Neither the government nor the police have any latitude in the matter as per the legal advice proffered by the Ad-

The resolution said that Karnataka would constitute a committee to suggest measures to correct the “lacunae” in the report through appropriate modifications. The Centre, on July 27, issued the seventh draft notification on ESA based on the report, which comprises 20,668 sq. km of areas across 10 districts. The State’s stand on ESA would mean reducing it to about 16,000 sq. km.



Breakdown of civic infra in India

The breakdown of civic infrastructure is killing ordinary and unassuming citizens every day. Lives are now lost in India due to abject governance failure rather than to natural or traditional causes. Further, citizens’ growing apathy towards governance failure is also concerning.

The age-old practice of blaming the Central and State governments is getting tiresome as it is clear that these incidents are fundamentally caused due to systemic failure, bureaucratic greed, absence of strict enforcement, and brazen entitlement of the general public.

Be it an illegal billboard in Mumbai that killed ordinary bystanders, or illegally constructed buildings that are constantly collapsing in Delhi, the same storyline follows – the police arrest the accused, suspend a few officials, a compensation is awarded (read: blood money) to the next of kin, and a vague promise to carry out a strict investigation is given. A few days later, it fades from public memory until the next tragedy occurs and conversations around civic responsibility and governance failure are reignited. One thing that is absolutely clear from these series of events is that administrative officials are privy to illegal activities, and it is their connivance that fuels the public’s brazenness to break regulations.

Another common feature is that the accused responsible for the mishap usually has prior criminal offences registered against them. Despite this, they continue engaging in illegal activities because the message from the system is



Prachi Dutta

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loud and clear – that there is no accountability for individual actions and as long as corruption is fuelling the system, officials will turn a blind eye. Officials who fail in their responsibility of upholding civic order should be held liable. An official who clears or knowingly ignores an unauthorised structure should face the same consequences as the owners who built it. It is only then that one can work towards trying to enforce regulations.

Poor urban planning

While India’s population size is an administrative hurdle that is unique to India, poor urban planning has exacerbated the problems caused by population pressure. A case in point are unauthorised colonies in Delhi that mushroom rapidly. The fact that these colonies are exempt from urban planning regulations gives building owners a free pass to build structures without any approval; a form of sanctioned impunity.

The entitlement of building owners is also significant. Be it in an upscale residential area or in an unauthorised colony in Delhi, building owners encroaching upon public land for their private use is a common occurrence in India. The reason for the brazenness is simple – no collective municipal drive has thoroughly addressed and deterred private encroachment.

One routinely reads about symbolic anti-encroachment drives; but most such drives are targeted at the marginalised groups of society who cannot retaliate. Selective enforcement is not enforcement, and in fact condones certain classes of encroachment. Civic action must target all private

encroachment with equal scrutiny in order to ensure compliance with norms.

In 2025, a fire broke out in a bar in Goa when fireworks were used indoors during a performance. The limited escape routes and crowding led to several people dying in the fire. While this particular outlet is permanently closed and the owners were arrested, what is upsetting is that consumers continue to patronise other establishments owned by the same owners.

In the U.S., established food and coffee chains have reported a slowdown in sales because of consumer boycott movements due to the political stance of these chains. If consumer boycott movements can lead to a slowdown of global conglomerates, then Indian consumers should also boycott establishments that have brazenly violated rules that have led to loss of life.

However, for an ordinary citizen who may not remember the incident, lack of access to compliance information such as publicly displayed compliance certificates in establishments and a public registry of violation norms, makes it harder for them to make an informed choice. Lack of access to this information is a governance failure, and access to it may be a step towards strengthening compliance with regulatory norms.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, establishments across India were under strict operating guidelines. Any deviation resulted in their immediate closure. The same enforcement must continue to be applied, and all buildings must be monitored to ensure compliance with guidelines.

Reiterating the basics of criminalisation

For four decades, the Uttar Pradesh Gangsters and Anti-Social Activities (Prevention) Act, 1986 dealt with gangsters and anti-social activities in the State. However, on August 20, a two-judge Bench of the Supreme Court in *Shiv Pratap Singh vs. State of U.P. and Himanshu Srivastava vs. State of U.P.* ruled: “the U.P. Act is still-born and the proceedings under it cannot survive”. The reasons for arriving at this harsh conclusion were spelled out by Justice J.B. Pardiwala and Justice K. Vinod Chandran thus: “A gangster is defined under the Act and the determination of who a gangster is, for the purpose of punishment, is as prescribed in the Rules, left to the *ipse dixit* of the Executive. The creation of a crime, or to make an act or omission subject to penal consequences as an offence, is essentially a legislative function and it cannot be thrown away and left to sprout in the thicket of subordinate legislation”.

This ruling centres around three inquiries – first, the need for the ‘creation’ of the crime by explicitly identifying the act made punishable by law; second, criminal law-making as exclusively a legislative function; and third, the desirability of excluding the executive from the rule-making and guilt-determination function.

For a society like ours which is used to ‘name-calling’ at will (*deshdrohi*, ‘urban naxal’ etc), it is very important to understand the value of clearly defining categories such as ‘crime’ or ‘offence’. The idea of criminalisation is rooted in the principle of



B.B. Pande

Former Professor of Law, Delhi University

legality that draws inspiration from the maxims *nullum crimen sine lege* (no crime without law), *nulla poena sine lege* (no punishment without law), and the prohibition against ex-post facto legislation. Relying upon the principle of legality, Article 20(1) of the Constitution creates a right against conviction except for violation of a law in force at the time of the act charged as an offence, and against a penalty greater than what the law in force prescribed. In the context of the U.P. Act, the Supreme Court relied upon the definition of “offence” as employed by the General Clauses Act. Applying this test, the Court concluded, “The penal law under which the criminal proceeding is initiated should create an offence and the punishment should also be in accordance with whatever the law prescribes... We cannot find any offence having been created.”

A function of legislature

Professor Herbert L. Packer, in his classic *The Limits of the Criminal Sanction* (1968), elaborated on the assignment of functions to diverse agencies for defining crime and punishment, observing: “This definitional role is assigned primarily and broadly to the legislature, secondarily and interstitially to the courts, and to no one else”. In the U.P. Act case too, the Court expressed strong reservations against leaving matters relating to crime or punishment at the mercy of subordinate legislation. The reasoning behind this advocacy for legislative action, as against subordinate legislative action, is to ensure detailed debate and due deliberation at the stage of enacting a criminal law. Problems arise when the

opinions of the executive are accepted unquestionably in matters of categorisation and punitive action. Section 23 of the U.P. Act provides special provisions for trial, bail, and rule-making power. Chapter 3 of the Act prescribes the procedure for preparing the ‘gang chart’. In this and in many earlier cases, challenges have arisen over the operation of the Rules in arriving at the decision to accord the status of ‘gangster’ to someone or the quantum of punishment, with it repeatedly being argued that executive authorities reach conclusions of culpability without verifiable evidence or reasoning. The Court ruled, “In the context of mere status being punished, which is determined by the administrative and police authorities by the preparation of a gang chart, nothing remains to be considered by the judicial officer but to punish him... The end result of a trial under the U.P. Act is a foregone conclusion, a statutory imprimatur to punish”. The Court reinforced its stand against the *ipse dixit* of the Executive with hard-hitting reasoning: “However compelling or threatening the social menace, any penal enactment to curb that, it cannot lead to arbitrary and capricious actions against the one, alleged with the commission of an offence”.

This categorical SC ruling is laudable. It has not only laid out an elaborate agenda for a reform of the Gangster Act, but has forthrightly reiterated the basics of criminalisation and the limits within which agencies are supposed to operate.

The influence of Dalit voters in Uttar Pradesh

While the BSP has remained the most popular choice among Dalit voters, the BJP is steadily gaining ground particularly within the non-Jatavs

DATA POINT

Sanjay Kumar
Vibha Attri

More than six months ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, political parties are already looking for issues that can help them mobilise voters. The Congress rally addressed by Mallikarjun Kharge at the Ramlila Ground in Haldwani, and the puja that was performed by some people afterwards, which has been described as a *shuddhikaran* (purification) puja, has emerged as one such issue that the Congress is seeking to capitalise on. Though the party knows that its Dalit support in the State is minuscule, it is trying to expand its appeal among Dalit communities.

For Uttar Pradesh, however, the larger question is not simply whether political parties will try to mobilise Dalit voters – they certainly will – but how much of the Dalit vote remains transferable, and which party or alliance can attract it in big numbers to make a difference in the 2027 Assembly election?

The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) had remained the most popular choice among the Dalit voters, though more so among Jatavs and slightly less so among non-Jatav Dalits. Over the years, a large number of Jatavs have voted for the BSP; however, some decline is visible in recent elections. When the BSP came to power in the State in the Assembly elections held in 2007, 86% of the Jatavs voted for the BSP while only 54% of non-Jatav Dalits voted for it. In the last Assembly elections held in 2022, this figure dropped to 65% among Jatavs, while its support among non-Jatav Dalits declined to 27% (Table 2 & 3). The BSP’s hold on the Dalit vote has weakened over the years. On the other hand, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has been able to make noticeable inroads among

this group, though these gains are still not sizable enough.

Dalit vote patterns

The pattern becomes even more striking when one looks into the voting pattern of Jatavs and non-Jatav Dalits separately.

The support for the BJP/National Democratic Alliance (NDA) among Jatavs increased from just 3% in 2002 to about 20% in the Assembly elections held in 2022, while the BSP’s support among Jatavs declined from 76% in 2002 to 65% in 2022 (Table 2). Among non-Jatav Dalits, the shift is noticeably sharper (Table 3). Here, the BJP/NDA support increased from 12% in 2002 to 40% in 2022, while the BSP’s support fell from 45% to 27% over the same period.

The data clearly suggest that the weakening of the BSP is not a mere fragmentation of the Dalit vote; rather, much of the vote that has moved away from the BSP has gone to the BJP, especially among non-Jatav Dalits.

Between 2002 and 2022, support for the BJP/NDA among non-Jatav Dalits has increased by 28 percentage points, compared to a 17-point increase among Jatavs.

The weakening of the BSP’s hold is also reflected in its overall decline in Uttar Pradesh. The party’s vote share declined from 30.4% in 2007 to 12.8% in 2022 (Table 1). Over the same period, the BJP/NDA’s vote share increased from 18.5% to 43.8%, while the Samajwadi Party (SP)/SP+ (plus means allies) also increased its vote share from 25.4% to 36.3%. The BSP’s overall vote share fell sharply, but both the BJP+ and SP+ have expanded their bases.

The Congress’s play

The Congress’s support amongst Dalit voters is extremely low, as it is among many other communities, but the party does not want to lose any chance and sees the Ramlila Ground incident as an opportunity to bring sections of Dalit voters back into its fold. It is

important to note that the Congress has failed to secure considerable Dalit support, be it among Jatavs or non-Jatav Dalits. Its vote share has remained in the single digits among both groups, with the exception of the 2012 Assembly elections, when the Congress secured 16% of the non-Jatav Dalit vote. Even in the 2012 elections, Congress’s gain among non-Jatav Dalits did not translate into a durable shift in its favour. By 2022, its support among this group had fallen back to just 4%.

While the Congress continues to make efforts to regain its Dalit support from the BSP, available data, however, suggest that Congress faces a difficult task. The weakening of the BSP has not, so far, translated into a significant recovery for the party among either Jatavs or non-Jatav Dalits.

Elections are due in early 2027, and parties will continue trying to mobilise Dalits as well as other caste communities. Only the results will indicate which party manages to successfully mobilise Dalit voters. But the data already provide an important indication – that the Dalit vote remains electorally important, and that it is no longer tied firmly to one party as it once was. The weakening of the BSP does not mean that Dalit voters have stopped having clear political preferences. Rather, the data suggest that the BJP has gained significantly from the BSP’s decline, particularly among non-Jatav Dalits, while the SP has also retained a meaningful share of Dalit support. The Congress, however, has so far failed to emerge as a significant beneficiary of this shift.

Given the sizable share of Dalit voters in Uttar Pradesh, their preferences are likely to remain important to the outcome of the 2027 Assembly election. The key question is therefore not whether the Dalit vote matters, but how transferable that vote has become and whether any party can consolidate support across Jatav and non-Jatav Dalits.

Split in the share

Data for the charts were sourced from Lokniti CSDS.



Who gets the vote: Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) supporters during a public meeting addressed by party chief Mayawati ahead of the Lok Sabha polls, in Moradabad, on April 15, 2024. PTI

Table 1: Performance of political parties in Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections from 2002 to 2022(%)					
	2002	2007	2012	2017	2022
BSP	23.06	30.43	25.91	22.23	12.88
BJP/NDA	23.6	18.45	15	41.35	43.82
SP/SP+	25.37	25.43	29.13	28.4	36.32
Congress/ Congress+	8.96	8.61	13.98	-	2.33

Congress currently receives only around four to five percent of the Dalit vote, but there was a time when Congress was the first and most popular choice of Dalit voters in U.P. While the party is actively trying to mobilise Dalit votes, it is yet to be seen how successful it will be

Table 2: How Jatavs voted in Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections from 2002 to 2022 (%)					
	2002	2007	2012	2017	2022
BSP	76	86	60	87	65
BJP/NDA	3	3	4	8	20
SP/SP+	2	3	13	3	9
Congress/ Congress+	4	2	5	-	1



Table 3: How non-Jatav Dalits voted in Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections from 2002 to 2022(%)					
	2002	2007	2012	2017	2022
BSP	45	54	44	44	27
BJP/NDA	12	12	7	33	40
SP/SP+	18	15	16	13	23
Congress/ Congress+	8	5	16	-	4

Note: Congress was in an alliance with SP during the 2017 Assembly elections

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Amount absorbed by RBI via overnight VRRR auction

71,971 in ₹ crore. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Tuesday absorbed ₹71,971 crore from the banking system through an overnight variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auction amid a huge surplus. Liquidity in the banking system is estimated to be in surplus of around ₹4.92 lakh crore as of September 21. PTI

Foreigners detained by Delhi police for ‘drug peddling, illegal stay’

191 The Delhi Police detained 191 foreign nationals during a month-long operation aimed at identifying people allegedly residing illegally in the city and suspected of involvement in drug peddling and other unlawful activities, officials said on Tuesday. The operation, named ‘Vista 1.0’, focused on verifying the visa and immigration status of foreign nationals. PTI

Refugees who fled to Djibouti amid fighting in Yemen

10,000 The number of refugees fleeing across the Red Sea to Djibouti jumped to 10,000 amid renewed fighting in Yemen, while displacement inside Yemen could swell to over 230,000, the UN warned Tuesday. The Iran-backed Houthis seized control of Yemen’s Red Sea coastline earlier this month. AFP

Respiratory cases in regions affected by haze in Indonesia

174,694 An official from Indonesia’s Health Ministry said Tuesday that more than 170,000 respiratory cases were recorded in regions affected by haze, as the country battles to control fires that caused the toxic smog. Blazes in Borneo, Sumatra and Papua have blanketed parts of the archipelago. AFP

Percentage decline in Samsung India’s profits in FY26

36 in per cent. the profit of Samsung India Electronics declined 36 per cent to ₹7,228.10 crore for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, according to a RoC filing by the consumer electronics major. However, its revenue from operations rose slightly by 1.2 per cent to ₹1.12 lakh crore in FY26, according to data from Tofler. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Towards recognising women farmers

Maharashtra’s passage of the Women Farmers’ Empowerment Bill, granting women independent recognition as farmers irrespective of land ownership, brings into focus the structural bias against the female agricultural workforce, highlights the need for a database of women farmers and using it to ensure access to welfare schemes

ECONOMIC NOTES

Sanchit Gupta
Tanu M. Goyal

Picture a farmer. The image that comes to mind is of a man. But when one looks at who is actually farming, she is increasingly likely to be a woman. This perception-reality mismatch is caused by age-old practices of collecting data, designing policies and defining who a farmer is. It makes millions of women who work on farms, make agricultural decisions and contribute to production nearly invisible. That may, however, finally be beginning to change.

In July 2026, Maharashtra passed the Women Farmers’ Empowerment Bill, granting women independent recognition as farmers irrespective of land ownership, through a Woman Farmer Certificate. This is the first Indian State legislation to give enforceable legal form to the activity-based, land-delinked definition of ‘farmer’ that the National Policy for Farmers set out in 2007 but never operationalised. The Bill arrives nearly two decades after that policy, and 15 years after a comparable law was first proposed at the national level (a lapsed bill introduced in the Rajya Sabha in 2011). It is, in effect, the culmination of three decades of women farmers’ movements backed by civil society organisations.

State-level efforts have also sought to recognise women farmers before this. Kerala’s Kudumbashree collectives have enabled women to participate in group farming, while Odisha’s KALIA scheme has reached landless and sharecropper women. But a women farmers’ registry delinked from land records had been missing. Maharashtra’s legislation, therefore, represents a potentially important shift, from recognising the owner of agricultural land to recognising the person who actually farms. This matters because women’s participation in agriculture has risen sharply.

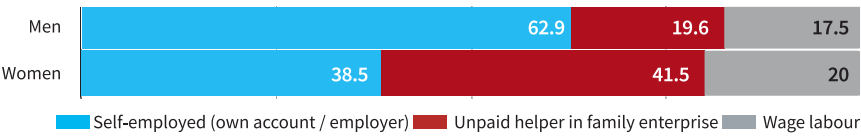
The recognition gap
In 2025, agriculture employed roughly 110 million women and 127 million men (rural, as per the PLFS, Census adjusted), bringing the sector close to gender parity. Women’s agricultural workforce has more than doubled since 2017-18, and nearly three-quarters of all rural women workers are now in agriculture, compared with less than half of men. Regrettably most women work without pay. In 2025, more than 41% of female agricultural workers were unpaid, against 20% of men (Chart 1). By contrast, nearly 63% of men were own-account workers compared with 39% of women. While women’s position has improved over time, the gap remains stark. This is where the question of recognition becomes critical, as women are increasingly farming but are not necessarily recognised as farmers.

The worker-owner dichotomy
In India, women largely work on the family lands, even though they may not own it or have their name on the land records, as patriarchal norms have meant that the land records are primarily in men’s names. Subsequently, only 14% of operational agricultural land holdings (as measured primarily through land records) are with women (according to the Agricultural

Unseen workforce

All States have women engaged in farming, but many remain unrecognised as farmers, leaving them out of databases and limiting their access to welfare schemes

Chart 1: Employment status of rural workers in agriculture and allied (% within each gender)



1 Nearly three-quarters of all rural women workers are employed in agriculture, compared with less than half of men

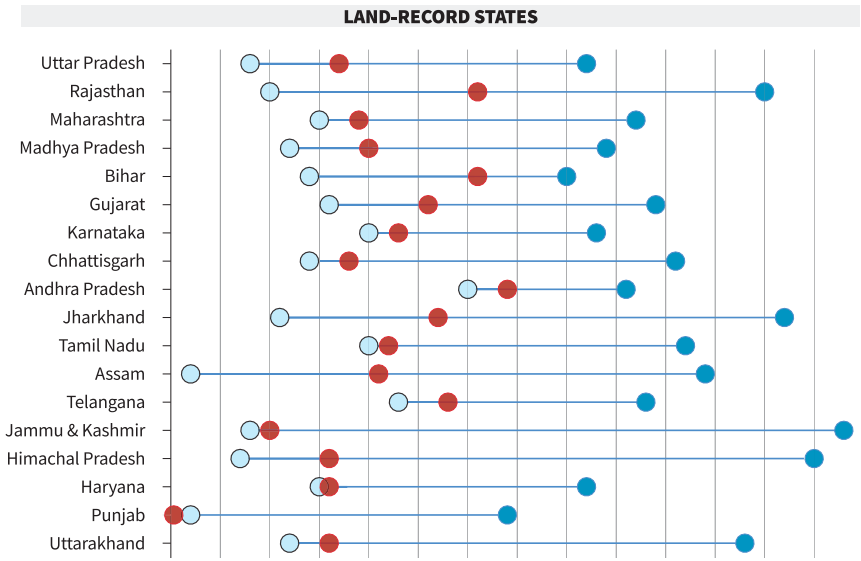


2 Women largely work on family land, though they may not own it or have their names on the land records

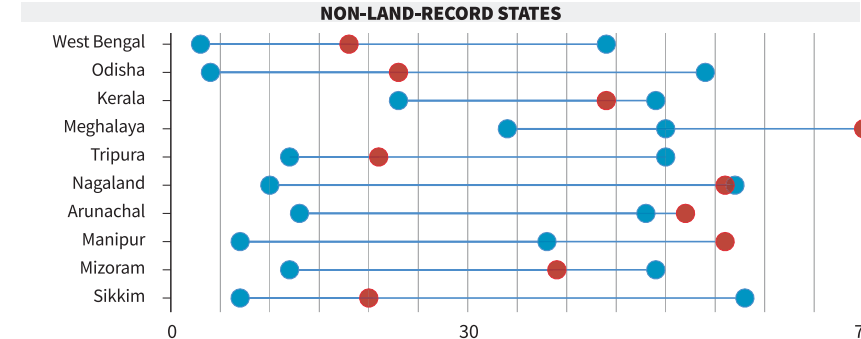
Source: Periodic Labour Force Survey 2025; rural workers aged 15+ in agriculture and allied sectors

Chart 2: Three measures for estimating the recognition gap

● Women as % of total agriculture and allied workers (2025, age 15+, usual status, rural+urban) ● Women operational holdings as % of total operational holdings (2015-16) ● Women beneficiaries as % of total PM-KISAN beneficiaries (2024, eligible)



■ PM-KISAN and operational holdings data sit 9 years apart. Where PM-KISAN’s share exceeds operational holdings share, it also reflects that the scheme counts individuals per landholding family (including successor widows), while the Census counts each holding once through land records - not necessarily translating into more land in women’s names. Punjab’s very low PM-KISAN share follows a large reduction in its beneficiary base over many successive instalments.



■ These States lacked standard land records for the Census and used sample estimates. PM-KISAN either used updated records or alternative methodology for Northeastern States among these, partly explaining the larger share of PM-KISAN women beneficiaries in them. Meghalaya’s high share reflects matrilineal inheritance, under which women are the customary landholders.

Note: States are ordered by the number of rural working women in agriculture (2025). Each dot is women’s share of a different total, in different years - of all agricultural workers, of all operational holdings, and of all scheme beneficiaries, approximating the recognition gap.

Source: Periodic Labour Force Survey 2025, Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation; Agriculture Census 2015-16, Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare; PM KISAN eligible beneficiary data, 2024

Census 2015-16). The person whose name is in the records gets included in the database and receives the benefits. As a result, not only does the recognition of women agricultural workers as farmers remain ambiguous, but they are also unable to access key Central and State agricultural schemes and incentives linked to land titles (land records).

All States have a large population of women engaged in farming who are never counted as farmers. Since each State uses its land revenue records as the source of truth for administrative purposes, the structural bias against women is carried forward into scheme access and databases. This ultimately translates into women farmers being unable to access credit, subsidies, technology, extension services and

The Maharashtra Act recognises women engaged in agriculture for at least one agricultural season a year, irrespective of the nature of the land

other related opportunities. For instance, only 23% of women have been beneficiaries of the Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi (PM-KISAN) scheme, which provides direct financial assistance of ₹6,000 per year to eligible landholding farmer families to support their agricultural expenses and household needs. For some States, the gap widens (See Chart 2).

Even in States where the share of women in the agriculture workforce is more than 50%, the share of women beneficiaries in most States is less than

one-third. The exceptions are revealing. Meghalaya, where women account for 70% of beneficiaries, followed by Kerala with 44% stand apart. These States have institutional or social arrangements that provide women with greater recognition or access to land and agricultural resources. In some northeastern States, customary tenure and matrilineal systems matter; in Kerala, collective farming through groups such as Kudumbashree provides an alternative route to participation and recognition.

At the other extreme are States with some of the widest gaps. In Jammu & Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh, women make up nearly two-thirds of the workforce but represent a small fraction of beneficiaries. The binding constraint, therefore, is not land itself but the identification system built on it. Where the land record is the gatekeeper, women are more likely to be filtered out; where an alternative mechanism exists, women’s access rises substantially.

Year of the Woman Farmer

While the Maharashtra legislation came after decades of advocacy, it is well timed. With the United Nations naming 2026 the International Year of the Woman Farmer, Maharashtra has taken a potentially transformative first step and paved the way for other States. The Maharashtra Act broadens the definitions of ‘agriculture’ and ‘farmer’ to recognise women residents engaged in agriculture for at least one agricultural season a year, irrespective of the nature of the land, through a ‘Woman Farmer Certificate’.

Importantly, it explicitly recognises categories like landless cultivator, landless livestock rearer, agricultural labourer, plantation labourer, and pastoralist. In principle, this creates a route through which women who do not own land can obtain an independent agricultural identity and gain access to state welfare schemes and credit. But recognition on paper is only the beginning. Implementation will require either self-registration or identification of women farmers by the Gram Sabha, including women who have no land or no land titles in their name. In both cases, this will require a robust information campaign.

This also provides for a new database of women farmers. Connecting this database with existing agricultural databases and avoiding duplication or exclusion will need to be worked out, presenting an opportunity for States to work together. A standardised system across States, for establishing common definitions for identifying women farmers, issuing certificates, and maintaining databases, would make it easier to link the identities of women farmers across schemes and administrative platforms, while avoiding multiple registrations.

But recognition must then translate into access. Linking these certificates to the Agri Stack (a digital platform developed by the Union Ministry of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare) and issuing FarmerIDs to the women is essential to integrating them into the broader digital agricultural ecosystem. However, for recognition to translate into empowerment, continuous efforts at the local level will be needed to make women farmers aware of the schemes and effectively ensure their access. (The authors work at the Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER). Views expressed are personal.)

THE GIST

▼ In July 2026, Maharashtra passed the Women Farmers’ Empowerment Bill. This is the first Indian State legislation to give enforceable legal form to the activity-based, land-delinked definition of ‘farmer’

▼ It explicitly recognises categories such as landless cultivators, landless livestock rearers, agricultural labourers, plantation labourers and pastoralists. In principle, this creates a route through which women who do not own land can obtain an independent agricultural identity and gain access to welfare schemes

▼ But recognition must then translate into access. Linking these certificates to Agri Stack and issuing Farmer IDs to women is essential to integrating them into the broader digital agricultural ecosystem

BUILDING BLOCKS

From springs to superconductivity: a physics lesson from umbrellas

Springs are usually metal wires wound in a spiral, allowing us to store mechanical energy; the umbrella's rod consists of multiple cylinders, and the spring opens them up in succession; when you close an umbrella, you compress the spring and store energy in it

Adhip Agarwala

Well after a few months of a hectic summer, rains are here. The campus is green and nature is once again abundant. With rains, however, has also come a usual game of hide and seek. Every time I take my umbrella out, the rain is nowhere to be seen. But when I forget it, I am greeted by sudden bouts of rain, spoiling my ambition to reach my class dry and tidy.

Umbrellas, however, have something amazing about them. You press a button and it automatically opens up, stretches itself, and unfolds into a shade, growing much larger than it was. Like a magical genie.

Have you wondered how an umbrella works? You only applied a small amount of energy to push the button. Where did it get all this energy to open up so big?

As always, we are on the cusp of some beautiful physics.

Spring forth

If you have ever broken up an umbrella, you would have seen a spring inside the main rod. That is the most crucial piece.

Springs are usually metal wires wound in a spiral, giving it a remarkable mechanical property: it becomes a ‘mechanical battery’. Just like batteries allow us to store electrical energy, springs allow us to store mechanical energy. Once pressed, the springs try to come back to their original size and exert a force on its end.

How much force? That depends on how much you have compressed it. The more you compress, the greater the force. The British physicist Robert Hooke discovered this 350 years ago; the relationship between the compression and the force is today called Hooke's law.

Incidentally, you must have seen batteries and springs together. Where? Well, every time you try to fit a battery into the sockets in a remote control. The spring keeps the battery snug and tight, and the fact that it is made of metal allows for electrons to easily flow into a circuit from the battery through the spring.

The strength of springs is often quoted in newtons per millimetre, or N/mm. Here, ‘newton’ is the unit of force and ‘metres’ is the unit of distance. A newton is about the force a medium-sized apple exerts on your hand. You can easily see a millimeter on a regular stationary scale. Now, a usual spring you may have seen in a battery socket faces about 1 N/mm. So when you try to tuck a battery in, that battery compresses the spring and the spring in turn pushes on the battery by about one newton of force, to keep it in its place, so that it doesn't fall, and keeps the circuit connected.

But that's just one spring you see. You are in fact surrounded by springs, just that they are hidden. The sofa you sit on while entertaining a guest, the mattress you collapse onto after a day of office work, and even your car or scooter where you spend hours managing rainy-season potholes – all of them have several springs to make sure you are comfortable.

If you have ever paid close attention to our trains or metro rails, you might have noticed large springs under the coaches or hanging on the top. These springs help stabilise the train as it moves over uneven



The mechanics within: An umbrella's rod consists of multiple cylinders, one around the other, and the spring opens them up in succession. R.V. MOORTHY

terrain. And they can reach up to strengths of hundreds of N/mm.

Now, even though you may have noticed the spring, the real physics question is why it stores any energy at all. And what type of force does it exert?

Forces in nature

In physics, we think of four fundamental forces. One is the electromagnetic force, which decides how electric charges move and magnets attract. The second is the gravitational force, due to which we don't fly off and remain stuck to the ground. The two other forces are called strong and weak forces: they work at very small distances, like inside the nucleus of an atom.

The force created by springs does not seem to be any of these four options. So what is it?

Turns out that even the spring's force is secretly an electromagnetic force. Think of any metal, say aluminium. It has billions of aluminium atoms arranged like oranges on fruit carts. These atoms have a massive positively charged nucleus and negatively charged electrons that are very light. Electromagnetism teaches us that positively charged particles repel each other while positives and negatives attract. Now, in a metal, even though the atoms stay in their places, the electrons move around, spending their time near whichever atom they like.

The atoms are like residents in a colony who do not get along with each other. But then all of them have kids (the electrons), which form a group and love hanging out at all the houses in the neighborhood. The kids are loved by all, and everyone

takes care of them. So the kids hold the whole neighborhood together.

But remember: the nucleus of the two atoms still repel each other, since they are both positively charged. So the atoms strike a deal. The two nuclei of the atoms decide to build homes at some convenient distance, where they can tolerate each other even while their electrons can happily move between the houses.

Now, when you try to push any material from one side, the distances between these atoms become squished. The positively charged nuclei come closer than they want to, and since positive charges repel each other, they now push back. This is how the elastic force of any material arises.

Vibrations and sound

Now, while one spring can push back, a lot of them arranged together in a material can do something more: they can vibrate together.

Think of a sofa with many springs beneath. When you jump at one end (of course you need to ignore the possibility of damaging it permanently!), you can feel the whole bed vibrating even at the other end. The same thing happens in water when you drop a stone at one point. Water molecules vibrate and push and pull on nearby molecules as well, leading to a ripple.

Even in a solid material like iron or aluminum, when we strike one end, we make small changes to the position of atoms at that point. These atoms push and pull nearby atoms using those elastic forces. These vibrations can move at very high speed throughout the material. They

are called sound waves. If a steel plate falls from your hand on the floor, the vibrations and sound you hear moves through the plate at a speed of about 20,000 km/hr and reaches you over air molecules at about 1,000 km/hr.

Sound and superconductivity

It may seem that the vibrations of positively charged atoms and the movement of negatively charged electrons do not bother each other much. And they do not, at least not significantly, when they are at room temperature. This is why metals behave like metals when we see them.

But when the temperature drops, atoms and electrons can do funny things. For instance, atoms can conspire to generate attraction between two negatively charged electrons.

Imagine two atoms (neighbours) that move closer together using the spring that connects them, to attract a few kids to their garden for a moment. Now, once one electron (Bunty) moves towards them, another electron (Bubly) notices and also approaches the same neighborhood. As they move, another set of neighbours on a different road do the same thing. So, Bunty and Bubly will continue following each other and form a pair even though they did not mean to move together.

This pair of electrons is now called a Cooper pair, named after Leon Cooper, a U.S. physicist who won a Nobel Prize in 1972 for discovering this mechanism.

So what if two electrons start attracting each other? Turns out this formation of Cooper pairs leads to superconductivity. This is an extraordinary phenomenon: where a metal decides to completely change its character and start conducting electric currents without any resistance. Your electricity bills would nosedive if such materials could exist at room temperature.

Most metals become superconductors but at very low temperatures. Aluminum, often used to make your pressure cookers, becomes a superconductor at -271.9 C. Even though scientists discovered superconductivity more than a century ago, even today they don't understand all aspects of it. It really requires quantum mechanics to understand, and is one of the most active areas of research in quantum condensed matter physics – which is the study of quantum materials around us.

Back to umbrellas

Finally, our most important question: why does an umbrella need that big spring?

The umbrella's rod consists of multiple cylinders one around the other, and the spring opens them up in succession. When you close an umbrella, you compress the spring and store energy in it – essentially squishing billions of atoms slightly closer together than they want to be. This gets locked by a hook. When you press the umbrella button, the hook releases to let the spring push out again.

Next time, when you open an umbrella and walk in the rain, don't forget to thank the billions of atoms and their small inter-atomic springs, which are also breathing a sigh of relief.

(Adhip Agarwala is an Assistant Professor of physics at IIT Kanpur.)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the difference in meaning between “We have lived here for five years” and “We have been living here for five years”? (Y.V.P. Kumar, Tirutanni)

As, far as the meaning is concerned, there is no difference between the two. What you are saying is that you started living in that particular place five years ago and you still continue to live there. The activity of living in that place – if you would like to call it that – still continues. Here are a few examples.

Naresh has worked here for fifteen years. (He still works here)

Naresh has been working here for fifteen years. (He still works here)

Naresh worked here for fifteen years. (He no longer works here)

This however is not possible in the case of all verbs. For example, you cannot say, “I have read the book for three weeks”, or “I have eaten since yesterday”.

On the other hand, you can say, “I have been reading the book for three weeks” and “I have been eating since yesterday”.

What is the meaning of the expression “on the receiving end”? (S. Ponnammal, Coimbatore)

When you are “on the receiving end” of something bad or unpleasant, you are the person who suffers. You are the individual who is subjected to hurt and humiliation. One can also “be at the receiving end” of something bad. Here are a few examples.

The newly appointed lecturer was at the receiving end of all the bullying.

He was on the receiving end of all the hatred that she felt for men in general.

What is the meaning of “cock-a-hoop”? (Venkat Ramana, Visakhapatnam)

When one is “cock-a-hoop” about something, one is extremely happy or pleased about it. You are usually delighted about something that you have done. The main stress is on the word “hoop”. “Cock-a-hoop” is considered to be rather old fashioned. Here are a few examples.

Jai was cock-a-hoop about the way the cake turned out.

We were all cock-a-hoop about winning the first prize.

Isn't a female cat also called a “tabby”? (Terry Lalachan, Alappuzha)

Yes, a female cat can be referred to as a “queen” or a “tabby”.

What is the meaning of the idiom “to rob Peter to pay Paul”? (K. Giri Srikanth, Kurnool)

When you rob Peter to pay Paul what you are doing is taking money from one person in order to pay another. You are not actually clearing your debts; all that you are doing is paying off one person by borrowing from another. As a result, you still continue to be in debt. Here are a few examples.

Tara took a loan from the bank in order to clear her debts; robbing Peter to pay Paul.

I am not going to ask my neighbour for some for money in order to pay you. It would be like robbing Peter to pay Paul.

Some people use one credit card to pay off the bills of another credit card. It's like robbing Peter to pay Paul.

Published in The Hindu on January 22, 2002

THE DAILY QUIZ

Neptune was the first planet to be discovered through mathematical prediction before telescopic observation confirmed its existence. A quiz on the hunt for this planet

Prathmesh Kher

- QUESTION 1**
- Which planet's irregular orbital motion led astronomers to hypothesise the existence of another, more distant planet?
- QUESTION 2**
- On which dates in September 1846 was Neptune first successfully observed?
- QUESTION 3**
- Which astronomer had observed Neptune in 1612–13 without recognising it as a planet?
- QUESTION 4**
- What was the name of the star chart that helped Johann Gottfried Galle and Heinrich d'Arrest identify Neptune?
- QUESTION 5**
- Approximately how close was Neptune to Urbain Le Verrier's predicted position when Galle found it?



Visual question: This image of Neptune was taken by which NASA space probe, and when? NASA

Questions and answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. The only person connected with both the first and second tied Test matches. **Ans: Bob Simpson (a player in the first tied Test held in 1960 and was the Manager of the Australian side in the second)**

2. They were declared as players in the match from the respective sides. **Ans: Kapil Dev & Dean Jones**

3. While Greg Matthews took five in both innings, this Australian bowler took the remaining five Indian wickets in their second innings. **Ans: Ray Bright**

4. He became the first player to make 100 consecutive Test

appearances during this historic Test. **Ans: Sunil Gavaskar**

5. He deputised for regular Wicketkeeper Kiran More after he left the field on the first day due to food poisoning. **Ans: Chandrakant Pandit**

6. This player Wicketkeeper of Australia in that Test. **Ans: Tim Zoehrer**

7. This Indian allrounder remained unbeaten with a gritty 48 after ensuring that India would not lose that Test match. **Ans: Ravi Shastri**

Visual: Identify the Umpire who declared the last man, Maninder Singh, out LBW. **Ans: V. Vikramraju**

Early birds: K.N. Viswanathan | Sunil Madhavan | Tamal Biswas | Aryan Wari | Sudhir Thapa

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

Word of the day

Facetious: cleverly amusing in tone

Synonyms: bantering, tongue-in-cheek

Usage: *His facetious response was intended to lighten the mood.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/facetious

International Phonetic Alphabet: /fəˈsiːʃəs/

Can't penalise refusal to sing National Song: SC

Trade deal 'unlikely' till U.S. completes probes

Girl gang-raped at public park in Delhi

CM
K

Can't be held liable for acts of party cadre, wings: Stalin

Drug trade will be uprooted from the country by the end of 2029, says Shah

Wangchuk slams delay in making probe findings public

Sharjeel gets interim bail for cousin's wedding

ED's petition is an abuse of process of law: Sonia, Rahul

'4,812 books removed from J&K libraries'

M ND-NDE

Cong. slams
EC silence
on ‘attack’ on
party convoy

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Tuesday questioned the Election Commission’s silence regarding the alleged attack on a convoy carrying former Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel, who is also the All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary for Assam; State party chief Gaurav Gogoi; and other party leaders during campaigning for the bypoll in the Nagaon Lok Sabha seat. The party sought an independent probe into the incident.

The convoy faced stone-pelting in the Samaguri Assembly segment on Monday, which the Congress termed as a “planned murderous attack” aimed at intimidating its leaders and workers ahead of the October 6 bypoll. The party said acid had been thrown at the convoy and that masked assailants used iron rods in the attack. It also alleged that the incident had taken place despite the administration being alerted about the possibility of trouble.

Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh said the incident was not an isolated event but a “shameful attempt” by the BJP, with the “tacit approval” of the Election Commission, to avert a likely defeat by resorting to violence.

Notices for Delhi SIR seem ‘mechanically issued’, says top court

It asks poll body if recipients at least know what ‘logical discrepancies’ they have to resolve; vague notices risk disenfranchising lakhs, says petition

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Tuesday said the notices sent by the Election Commission (EC) during the special intensive revision (SIR) in Delhi to over 33 lakh voters due to ‘logical discrepancies’ or ‘no mapping’ with previous electoral records seem to be “machine-generated” without any application of mind.

“Some refinement is necessary. These look like mechanically issued notices. In all probability, they are machine-generated notices... Please examine if some additional filters are necessary,” Justice Joymaya Bagchi, part of a three-judge Bench with Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V. Mohana, addressed the EC counsel, senior advocate Dama Seshadri Naidu.

Justice Bagchi asked the EC if the people to whom these notices were sent at least knew what logical discrepancies they had to prove incorrect.

Mr. Naidu said the deadline for notice disposal was October 29. “But we are open to extension since it [Delhi] is not election-bound,” he submitted.



Voters who were issued notices appear for a hearing at a school in New Delhi on September 17. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

He assured the top court that not a single name would be deleted and reasons had been assigned in the notices sent to voters.

Advocates Prashant Bhushan and Neha Rathi and activists Anjali Bhardwaj and Amrita Johri referred to how 91% of the voters in West Bengal who appealed against the logical discrepancies had been added to the roll. “But the whole process of getting back into the electoral roll would take years,” Mr. Bhushan submitted.

The court said the Delhi SIR may need better orientation. Some key figures who were sent notices include External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, former Delhi Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal, current Chief Mi-

nister Rekha Gupta, former Deputy Prime Minister L.K. Advani and senior advocate Kapil Sibal.

The petition said the term ‘logical discrepancies’ was not defined by the EC. There were neither parameters to determine the circumstances in which an elector would fall within that category nor any document or instruction regarding this aspect posted on the website.

It contended that issuance of vague notices would make lakhs of electors vulnerable to an arbitrary process of potential disenfranchisement.

The court issued notice to the EC and sought a status report while listing the case for hearing after two weeks.

Conservationist wins *businessline* Changemaker of the Year award

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In an inspiring ceremony charged with emotion, gripping stories of human achievement and a mellifluous classical fusion performance, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman presented *businessline*’s Changemaker of the Year award to grassroots conservationist Purnima Devi Barman for saving the endangered greater adjutant stork and empowering village women to become feisty protectors of the bird as well as self-reliant entrepreneurs.

Border Roads Organisation (BRO), which builds and maintains critical infrastructure in India’s remote border areas, was crowned Iconic Changemaker as was ‘pain doctor’ M.R. Rajagopal, founder and chairman emeritus of Pallium India, who integrated palliative care in mainstream healthcare services.

Receiving the award, Ms. Purnima Devi said, “When women rise, magic happens and the *hargila* (stork) takes flight.”

The eighth edition of the event saw awards being given in six categories – Digital Transformation, Social Transformation, Financial Transformation, Young Changemaker, Iconic Changemaker, and Changemaker of the Year. The Digital Transformation winner was Aparna Hegde,



Nirmala Sitharaman, Union Finance Minister; Raghuvir Srinivasan, Editor, *businessline*; and Nirmala Lakshman, Director and Publisher, The Hindu Group; pose with the awardees at the *businessline* Changemaker Awards ceremony in New Delhi on Tuesday. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR



founder of ARMMAN (Advancing Reduction In Mortality and Morbidity of Mother, Children and Neonates), a non-profit that uses technology to reach out to expectant mothers and guide them.

In the Social Transformation category, there were two winners – Project Sambandh, founded by Colonel Vembu Shankar (retired), which helps families of armed forces personnel who die while in service but not in combat, and Sankara Eye Foundation for scaling up free eye care. Financial Transformation winner was

Gourmet Popcornica for building a fully-integrated farm-to-consumer value chain across several States and giving a pop to the popcorn economy. The Young Changemaker award went to Ariana Agarwal, a 16-year-old girl from Jaipur for giving visibility to invisible gig workers.

‘Making a difference’
Acknowledging *businessline*’s role in bringing to the fore the work of changemakers, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said: “India is a vast country. Despite the States and Centre doing so much, it is the changemakers who are putting their heart and soul in their endeavours, who are making a difference on the ground.”

Earlier, inaugurating the event, Nirmala Lakshman, Director, THG Publishing Private Ltd., said, “Every year, this evening gives us a chance to recognise the

power of an idea to create change...and the persistence to see this through.”

Raghuvir Srinivasan, Editor, *businessline*, described how 1,600 nominations were received, from which the winners were chosen – a really tough job for the jury. “It was like a *samudra manthan* (churning of the ocean),” he said.

The 2026 awards function was presented by Sasthra Deemed University and powered by City Union Bank. Associate partners were State Bank of India, Life Insurance Corporation, Government of Andhra Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh Industrial Infrastructure Corporation, Citizen Watches, Government of Uttarakhand, Jammu & Kashmir Bank, NABARD, NTPC, Indian Bank, SAIL, GAIL (India) Limited, Essar Group, ICFAI Group, NMDC, and UCO Bank. The mobility partner was Kia Sorento.

UNSC seat bid keeps Jaishankar’s schedule packed

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India on Monday joined the Partnership for Multilateralism, endorsing the “non-superpower” grouping originally launched by the European Union (EU), Brazil, Canada and Kenya, and became an additional co-sponsor of the initiative along with Australia and Barbados.

The meeting of the grouping, called P4M, which is expected to build support for the United Nations and multilateralism, was one of several bilateral and multilateral meetings External Affairs Minister S.

Jaishankar took part in as he and the Indian delegation navigate a tough task list this week at the United Nations General Assembly.

On top of Mr. Jaishankar’s agenda this year is to garner support for India at next year’s election for the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) non-permanent membership for the 2028-2029 period.

Within a few hours of landing in New York on Monday, Mr. Jaishankar met with Foreign Ministers from France, Ecuador, Slovakia, Hungary, Ukraine, Moldova, and Switzerland. He also met the President of Naoero (Nauru), partici-



S. Jaishankar addresses the P4M summit. @DRSJAISHANKAR/X

pated in the P4M meeting, had another meeting with EU ministers, and attended an India-Visegrad group meeting with the Central European nations of Poland, Hungary, Slovakia and Czechia. On Tuesday,

he began his meetings with the 33-member Community of Latin American and Caribbean States.

The meetings with European leaders as well as expected meetings this week with his counterparts from the United States and Canada are also expected to prepare for Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s visits to Brussels, Miami and Ottawa in December.

Tajikistan’s candidature
Officials say the rest of Mr. Jaishankar’s schedule this week – he is expected to remain in New York until he addresses the General Assembly on Saturday –

will be equally packed.

Amid India’s bid for the UNSC membership for the Asia-Pacific group, Tajikistan has also launched its candidature for the seat. As a result, all eyes will be on any meeting between Mr. Jaishankar and Tajikistan Foreign Minister Sirojiddin Muhriddin.

In the wake of the U.S. Congress passing the Lindsey Graham Sanctions on Russia and Iran Act, which seeks to penalise countries importing oil from these countries, Mr. Jaishankar’s meeting with U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio this week will also be particularly significant.

At UN summit, Jaishankar calls for reformed multilateralism

Press Trust of India
UNITED NATIONS

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Monday stressed the need for reformed multilateralism at the first-ever ‘Partners for Multilateralism, International Law, Peace & Prosperity (P4M)’ Summit held on the margins of the high-level 81st session of the UN General Assembly. He also asserted that “at a time when the global order is under stress”, more participative deliberations and transparent decision-making were overdue.

Mr. Jaishankar co-chaired the summit, co-sponsored by India, along with leaders of Australia, Barbados, Brazil, Canada and Kenya. He said that for some decades, the world had witnessed a steady rebalancing, which was a long-expected structural evolution.

“However, extreme competition, geopolitical tensions and actual conflicts have given this an entirely different character. If left unchecked, it would call into question the very spirit of international cooperation, and that is

why it is so essential that multilateralism asserts itself strongly at this juncture,” he said.

“The ‘4F’ crisis of fuel, food, fertilizer and finance cannot be left to itself... And where there is a compelling cause or a powerful case, the like-minded must have the confidence to come together,” he said.

He stressed that multilateralism would be best served when international law, rules and norms were scrupulously observed. He said, “Reformed multilateralism is therefore essential.”

Terming it a “broad daylight dacoity” against patients, the Supreme Court on Tuesday expressed shock over the overpricing of essential cancer medicines, noting that one drug carried an MRP of ₹27,000 despite being supplied to retailers for ₹2,700. “It is very surprising that the authorities who are supposed to take action on this are silent,” a Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta said. The observations came when the court was hearing two petitions on drug-related issues, including that of ensuring strict price control over medicines. “The MRP is 10 times the rate at which it is provided to the retailers. If this is not extortion, then what it is?,” the Bench observed. ^{PTI}

The Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) has cautioned against the indiscriminate or prolonged use of painkillers and antibiotics, citing the associated risk of kidney damage. In a circular dated September 21, the regulator said non-steroidal anti-inflammatory drugs and antibiotics are regulated under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940 and the Drugs Rules, 1945, and should be sold on the prescription of a registered medical practitioner. The regulator advised the public not to self-medicate with antibiotics or use them for conditions where they are not clinically indicated, including most uncomplicated viral infections.

M ND-NDE

NEXT TARGET

‘Have to keep playing good cricket and look to win an Olympic medal’



R.V. MOORTHY

Smriti Mandhana was measured in her reaction, her ambitions clearly much bigger than continental domination. “We have to keep playing good cricket against better opposition. We can’t dwell on this win a lot, we have to see what we can do for the next one half to two years to get in the best place to win an Olympic medal”.

ELATED

I was all around... jumping, roaming and talking: Shreyanka



R.V. MOORTHY

It’s very hard when you have back-to-back injuries. If you stay positive and keep telling you can do it, anything is possible. When I was out there, I was all around jumping, roaming, and talking. It’s my first time holding a gold medal... I’m really grateful. I’m just happy to be back on the field — India’s Shreyanka Patil.

SAILING THROUGH

Jugraj, Abhishek and Dilpreet ‘trick as India hammers Lanka



X@AHF

The Indian men’s hockey team routed Sri Lanka 16-1 in its second Pool A match at the Asian Games on Tuesday. Jugraj Singh slammed four goals, while Abhishek and Dilpreet netted three each. Harmanpreet Singh struck twice while Mandeep Singh, Sukhjeet Singh, Manpreet Singh and Vivek Sagar Prasad also scored.

FANTASTIC RUN

Roshibina ensures a hat-trick of medals after entering wushu semis



FILE PHOTO

Roshibina Devi Naorem on Tuesday assured herself of a third successive Asian Games medal as she entered the semifinals of the women’s 60kg category in wushu. Roshibina was declared the winner on point difference over Macau’s Chu Man Sin in the last-eight stage at the Aichi Prefectural Martial Arts Hall.

Women in Blue retain gold in emphatic fashion

Smriti and Shafali provide the perfect launchpad with a scintillating 99-run opening stand; Richa’s cameo powers India to a daunting total before the spin quartet blows away the Lankans

ASIAN GAMES

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The Indian National anthem played for the first time at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games on Tuesday. A blistering opening partnership followed by a cracking innings and spin choke-hold ensured the country its first gold at the Games. Harmanpreet Kaur’s women retained their title in commanding fashion with a 147-run victory against Sri Lanka in the final at the Korogi Athletics Park in Nisshin. Chasing a massive 217-run target, Sri Lanka folded up for 69 in 15.4 overs, stumbling early on and never finding their footing as Deepti Sharma and Co. didn’t allow any breathing space to the Sri Lankan batters on a small ground. The damage with the ball was initiated, as with the bat, by Shafali Verma who sent back Imesha Dulani and Hasini Perera in consecutive overs to reduce the Islanders to 30 for two inside five overs. She didn’t bowl again but the collapse had begun and when Sri Lanka skipper Chamari Athapaththu was caught by Bharti Fulmali at long-off off Deepti, with the scoreboard reading 43 for three, it was all but over. Chamari was the top-scorer for Lanka with 29 (21b, 5x4), one of only



Undisputed champions: The Indian women asserted their class at the continental extravaganza with a thumping 147-run win in the final. R.V. MOORTHY

three batters to reach double digits in a line-up that had three ducks. Deepti scalped three while Shreyanka Patil and Shree Charani got two wickets each as Sri Lanka ended with yet another silver from the continental showpiece after the last edition

in Hangzhou. Earlier, having elected to bat, the Indians continued in the same vein as in the Asia Cup final nine days ago. Shafali (48, 29b, 3x4, 3x6) and Smriti Mandhana (79, 45b, 5x4, 7x6) were in imperious form. The two added 99 in the first 10 ov-

ers, scoring at over 150 strike rate each. Shafali, trying to go for a reverse sweep, failed to clear the infield, and missed out on a half-century. Richa Ghosh’s unbeaten 22-ball 49 (6x4, 3x6) was the icing on the cake and propelled the total beyond

200 after Harmanpreet fell for 19. Smriti’s sublime but equally destructive knock was the foundation of India’s daunting 216 for three. In the morning, Pakistan captain Fatima Sana’s 30-ball 45 and Umm-e-Hani’s three for 10 helped the team clinch the bronze

with a 31-run victory against Bangladesh in the playoff. **The scores (final):** India 216/3 in 20 overs (Shafali 48, Smriti 79, Richa 49 n.o.) bt Sri Lanka 69 in 15.4 overs (Chamari 29, Shafali 2/3, Deepti 3/6, Shreyanka 2/9, Shree Charani 2/13). **Toss:** India.

‘We will have this gold medal with us forever’

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

Harmanpreet Kaur has done what no one else can claim to have done, or may do for a while – be the captain of an Asian Games-winning cricket team twice in a row. And she has the medals to prove it. Firm favourite to defend its title at the Korogi Athletics Park even before the team landed in Tokyo, and coming after the high of clinching the Asia Cup, the gulf between the Women in Blue and the rest was far too wide. “As cricketers, we always wanted to be a part of the Asian Games or Commonwealth Games or Olympics, because otherwise we only play cricket tournaments. We did not

know the value of what a medal actually means. “We are lucky to have done it twice now because the cricketers before us did not have this. Now we can also frame two medals back home because when we win a trophy, it feels good but it goes to the BCCI office. This is something we will have with us forever... this is ours.” Harmanpreet said on Tuesday. That the team’s gold was also the first for India at the ongoing Games only made it extra special. “Our aim was to win gold and see the national flag high... [we] talked about the national anthem playing. But we didn’t know we would be the first to experience it here. I am sure that we have opened the golden gates”.



Joy! Harmanpreet added another feather to her cap. R.V. MOORTHY

Shooters Elavenil and Parth wilt under pressure of finals

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

India’s wait for a shooting gold at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games continued on Tuesday, as the country went medal-less on the third day of competition at the Aichi General Shooting Range, with Elavenil Valarivan and Parth Mane finishing fourth in the 10m Air Rifle mixed team event. Having finished strongly in second place behind China in qualifying, Elavenil and Parth were expected to get India another



Elavenil, PTI

shooting medal, but pressure got the better of the young shooters, who bowed out with a total of 376.3 after 18 shots each. Low scores of 103.6,

104.3 and 104.4 in the first three series pulled the Indians down, despite a superb showing in the fourth series that saw them shoot the highest total of 64. China, meanwhile, set a new World Record with a score of 507.1 to add another gold to its kitty while Korea took silver (502.9) and host Japan bronze (439.7). The Chinese pair of Sheng Lihao and Wang Zi-fei had already set a new qualifying World Record with a total of 638.9, more than four points ahead of India with 634.6.

SNAPSHOTS

Pranati in vault finals Pranati Nayak qualified for the Asian Games vault finals in the artistic gymnastics event on Tuesday. She was seventh among 19 gymnasts to have made the final, which will be held on Thursday.

Wrestler Deepak may travel to Japan Greco-Roman wrestler Deepak (67kg), who was removed from the Asian Games-bound Indian squad after testing positive for banned substance Clomifene, may travel to Japan after getting a favourable court order. Taking into account that Deepak was not provisionally suspended for the adverse analytical finding reported by the National Anti-Doping Agency, the Delhi HC on Tuesday directed relevant authorities, including the Government, to “consider” Deepak’s name and give “permissible relief” as per existing policy within three days. The wrestling squad is set to leave for Japan on Saturday. The court made it clear that it passed the order solely on the basis of Deepak’s petition.

Indian men shuttlers assured of a medal



First blood: Lakshya bounced back to win the opening match against Naraoka. REUTERS

Uthra Ganesan
NAGOYA

The Indian badminton teams had a mixed day at the Asian Games with the men assuring themselves of a medal after winning 3-0 against host Japan in the quarterfinal while the women went down 1-3 to the home team at the Ichinomiya City Municipal Gymnasium on Tuesday. It’s the first time in 40 years that the men’s team has won back-to-back medals at the Asian Games. **Women exit** The women, however, continue to wait for their first medal since the bronze in 2014. Lakshya Sen came back

from a game down to win the opening match against Kodai Naraoka 11-21, 21-15, 21-19 to set the tone. Lakshya trailed 13-19 before reeling off eight straight points to take the match and put India ahead 1-0. Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty then overcame Hoki Takuro and Yugo Kobayashi 21-18, 24-22 to make it 2-0 before Ayush Shetty sealed the tie with a comprehensive 21-10, 21-19 to ensure back-to-back podium finish for the Indian men. The women, however, were unable to find their rhythm. P.V. Sindhu, who started the proceedings, got off to a good start against World No. 3 Akane

INDIANS IN ACTION TODAY

Lanka 16-1.
Kabaddi: Men (Group A): bt South Korea 63-31.
Karate: Men’s kumite -84kg bronze medal bout: Chetan lost to Chung (Tpe) on Senshu after the contest ended 1-1.
Shooting: 10m air rifle mixed team qualification: Elavenil & Parth (fourth); Skeet individual qualification (day 2): Men: Anantjeet (tied for top spot with three others), Mairaj (tied for 22nd with two others), Bhavtegh (35th); Women: Raiza (fifth), Parinaaz (tied for ninth with another shooter), Maheshwari (tied for 15th with another shooter).
Swimming: Men: 1500m freestyle final: Aryan (12th overall); 4x100m medley relay final: Eighth.
Table tennis: Round-of-16: Women’s team: bt Thailand 3-2; Men’s team: lost to South Korea 0-3.
Wushu: Women: Nanquan & Nandao final: Langlontombi (ninth overall); Sanda 60kg quarterfinal: Roshibina bt Sin (Mac).

Yamaguchi but was unable to sustain the momentum, losing 23-21, 18-21, 6-21. Unnati Hooda couldn’t find a way past 2022 World Junior champion Tomoka Miyazaki to lose 16-21, 18-21. Recent World Championships bronze medalists Treesa Jolly and Gaya tri Gopichand gave some hope with a 21-17, 21-16 win against the world No.3 pair of Yuki Fukushima and Mayu Matsumoto. But former World champion Nozomi Okuhara outplayed Tanvi Sharma 21-12, 21-10 in just 18 minutes to wrap up the tie.

MIND NDE

